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Abstract

Purpose - This study examines how brand response styles influence customer sentiment in consumer-to-consumer (C2C) conflicts within online brand communities (OBCs). Specifically, it investigates whether the effects of assertive and cooperative brand responses differ across three conflict types: intragroup, intergroup, and outergroup conflicts. By doing so, the study aims to address the research gap in understanding how brand interventions shape post-conflict customer sentiment in real online community settings.

Method - This research adopts a netnographic approach and collects Reddit comment data from 68 brand-owned subreddits across 11 industries. A total of 1,148 conversations were initially collected, from which 495 C2C conflict conversations were manually identified and classified into intragroup, intergroup, and outergroup conflicts. Customer sentiment after brand intervention was measured using Google Natural Language Processing, while brand response styles were operationalized through LIWC-based assertiveness and cooperativeness indices. To test the hypotheses, the study employs a partition Least Squares Dummy Variables (LSDV) regression model with subreddit-clustered standard errors.

Findings - The findings show that C2C conflicts consistently depress customer sentiment across online brand communities, with intergroup conflicts generating the most negative emotional baseline. More importantly, the results reveal that brand response styles do not operate in a uniformly beneficial way across conflict settings. Response strategies that appear intuitively appropriate often backfire: assertive responses intensify negativity in intergroup conflicts, while cooperative responses can also worsen sentiment in both intergroup and intragroup disputes. Overall, the findings suggest that customers evaluate brand interventions not only in terms of identity protection, but also in terms of fairness, legitimacy, and communicative appropriateness. This indicates that the emotional consequences of brand intervention depend on the interaction between conflict boundary and the social meaning attached to the response style.

Value - This study contributes to the literature by extending research on C2C conflict management from identity-based explanations alone to a more integrated perspective combining Social Identity Theory and Organizational Justice Theory. It shows that brand responses are evaluated not only in terms of group loyalty, but also in terms of fairness, legitimacy, and interactional appropriateness. Methodologically, the study also contributes by combining netnography, manual conflict annotation, sentiment analysis, and partition LSDV regression to examine real-world brand interventions. Practically, it offers scenario-specific guidance for managers seeking to respond to online conflicts without further damaging community sentiment.

Keywords Consumer-to-consumer (C2C) conflicts; brand response styles; customer sentiment; online brand communities (OBCs); Social Identity Theory; assertiveness; cooperativeness; sentiment analysis

Table of Contents

Acknowledgements	4
1. Introduction	5
2. Literature Review	8
2.1 Definition of C2C conflicts and C2C conflict types.....	8
2.2 Typology of C2C conflict response strategies.....	9
2.3 Effects of C2C Conflict response strategies.....	11
2.4 Previous Research Methods	13
3. Hypotheses Development.....	14
3.1 The Main Effect of C2C Conflicts on Customer Sentiment	15
3.2 The Role of Assertiveness.....	16
3.3 The Role of Cooperativeness	16
4. Research Methods.....	17
4.1 Data Collection.....	17
4.2 Data Processing	19
4.3 Mathematical Model.....	20
5. Results and Hypotheses Testing	22
6. Discussion	25
7. Theoretical Implications	28
8. Managerial Implications.....	32
9. Limitations and Future Research	33
10. References.....	35

Table of Figures

Figure 1. C2C conflict example (PETA, 2024).....	6
Table 1. C2C Conflict Types. (Adopted from (Dineva & Daunt, 2023))	9
Figure 2. Conflict Management Theory.....	10
Table 2. Summary of Hypotheses.....	15
Table 3. Data Source.....	18
Equation 1. LSDV Mathematical Model	22
Table 4. Regression results summary table.....	23
Table 5. C2C conflict response strategy matrix.....	33

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1. Introduction

With the proliferation of Online Brand Communities (OBCs), the nature of consumer interactions has fundamentally transformed. While OBCs serve as vital platforms for brand-consumer engagement and value co-creation, they have increasingly become hotbeds for Consumer-to-Consumer (C2C) conflicts. C2C conflicts are situations where users dispute, criticize, or exhibit hostility toward one another (Chandrasapth et al., 2021; Dineva et al., 2023). Unlike isolated offline disagreements, C2C conflicts in OBCs are highly visible, permanent, and contagious. Because brand communities are built upon shared social identities, these public disputes often transcend simple disagreements, evolving into severe identity threats that can rapidly spiral into negative electronic word-of-mouth (eWOM), paralyze user participation, and collapse the community's emotional sentiment. Consequently, active brand intervention is no longer merely an option for community managers; it is an operational imperative. However, navigating these turbulent social dynamics presents a precarious challenge: how a brand chooses to communicate during a crisis can either extinguish the fire or inadvertently pour fuel on it.

To illustrate the strategic dilemma of brand intervention, consider a quintessential conflict on the PETA (People for the Ethical Treatment of Animals) social media page (See Figure 1). Following a post advocating for animal welfare, a heated C2C dispute erupted between ideological supporters (the in-group) and skeptical meat-eaters or internet trolls (the out-group). As users exchanged hostile remarks, PETA intervened with a highly assertive stance, directly confronting the skeptics: "t truly is so awful. A life spent in a tiny cage, deprived of everything natural and kind, only to face a horrific end—it's unbearable to imagine. Ditch the cruelty and #govegan" (PETA, 2024). From a traditional perspective, this assertive defense of the core community's ideology should rally the in-group and bolster their social identity. However, it raises a critical empirical question: Does such an aggressive and unyielding posture de-escalate the tension and improve the overall sentiment of the community, or does it violate the implicit rules of social decorum, thereby exacerbating the hostility? This real-

world scenario highlights a critical gap in our understanding of crisis communication: the effectiveness of a brand's response style (assertive or cooperative) may be highly contingent upon the social boundaries of the actors involved in the conflict.

[Original post by: PETA (People for the Ethical Treatment of Animals) 🐷]

WTO GO GAN

User A:

So awful. Their entire life in a tiny cage, no grass, no sunlight, no love. Babies taken or die. Then a horrific end.

User B [replying to User A]:

User A not true at all

Pigs are outdoors in pens

Ever see what wild pigs do

See if peta will show that

PETA (People for the Ethical Treatment of Animals) 🐷 [replying to User A]:

It truly is so awful 😞 A life spent in a tiny cage, deprived of everything natural and kind, only to face a horrific end—it's unbearable to imagine 😞 Ditch the cruelty and #govegan 🙌 <https://how-to-go-vegan.peta.org/>

WTO GO GAN

User A [new comment later in the same thread]:

It truly is so awful 😞 A life spent in a tiny cage, deprived of everything natural and kind, only to face a horrific end—it's unbearable to imagine 😞 Ditch the cruelty and #govegan 🙌 <https://how-to-go-vegan.peta.org/>

User C [replying to User A]:

User A Where on earth do you live? Where I live they are in the fields

User D [replying to User A]:

User A don't be blind, uk aren't allowed to do as you "think"

User E [replying to PETA]:

PETA (People for the Ethical Treatment of Animals) tastes nice 🍖

User F [replying to PETA]:

PETA (People for the Ethical Treatment of Animals) update your pictures you

Figure 1. C2C conflict example (PETA, 2024)

Despite the growing prevalence of such digital friction, academic literature has only recently begun to systematically dissect brand interventions in C2C conflicts. Prior research has established that communication styles, specifically assertiveness (conveying authority and directness) and cooperativeness (conveying empathy and accommodation), significantly influence audience perceptions (Dineva et al., 2023). Modern OBCs frequently face intergroup conflicts (clashes between rival brand factions) and outergroup conflicts (attacks from non-members or general internet users). According to Social Identity Theory (SIT), individuals evaluate actions based on "in-group favoritism" and "out-group derogation" (Tajfel & Turner, 2004). Therefore, a brand response that is perceived as protective in an internal dispute might be viewed as a public relations disaster in an external one, and vice versa. The failure to account for these distinct conflict boundaries limits the predictive power of current theoretical frameworks and leaves practitioners without actionable, scenario-specific guidelines.

To bridge this gap, this study empirically investigates how the social boundaries of C2C conflicts (intragroup, intergroup, and outergroup) moderate the effect of brand response styles (assertiveness and cooperativeness) on customer sentiment. Drawing upon Social Identity Theory and Organizational Justice Theory, this research utilizes a partition Least Square Dummy Variables (LSDV) regression model to analyze a robust dataset extracted from Reddit communities. The findings reveal a complex reality: while conflict inherently depresses community sentiment, interventions that intuitively seem appropriate often backfire, exacerbating negative emotions. By delineating the boundaries where traditional identity-protection strategies fail and where communication decorum prevails, this study makes significant theoretical contributions to the C2C conflict literature and provides a pragmatic matrix for brand managers to navigate the increasingly hostile landscape of online communities.

2. Literature Review

2.1 Definition of C2C conflicts and C2C conflict types.

Built on classical social conflict theory (Coser, 1957; Kriesberg, 2007), Husemann and Luedicke (2013) conceptualized C2C conflicts as: "an interactive relationship between market participants pursuing incompatible goals related to scarce resources or conflicting ideologies". Since this research focus on C2C conflicts in OBCs, a simpler definition is situations where consumers disagree or dispute with each other in OBCs. This research is followed by (Husemann et al., 2015), who categorized consumption social conflict into routinized conflicts and transgressive conflicts. Afterward, Dineva et al. (2020) proposed five C2C conflicts' characteristics: aggressive tone, emotional intensity, reciprocal escalation, moral framing, and polarized group dynamics. Drawing on Jung's personality traits theory, Chandrasapth et al. (2022) researched the traits of the customers who participate in the C2C conflicts. Dineva et al. (2023) have raised five sources of C2C conflicts: Attack, Dissatisfaction, Skepticism, Contention, and Defense. Eventually, Dineva and Daunt (2023) combined the empirical research to conclude the C2C conflict types and characteristics. There are three types of C2C conflicts: inter group conflicts, intra group conflicts, and outer group conflicts, and seven characteristics: Two-way exchange interactive, Conflict actors, Underlying conflict object, Rude or insulting diatribe, Emoticons and acronyms, Capitalized words and sentences, Multiple punctuation marks. This research will follow the framework proposed by (Dineva & Daunt, 2023) to examine different brand responses' effects under these three C2C conflicts types because the framework can be explained by the Social Identity Theory. In Table 1, the author lists the definitions and examples of each C2C conflict type. Nevertheless, a research gap exists here, that is C2C conflicts should be regarded as a moving process instead of a static and invariable force (Chandrasapth et al., 2021).

C2C conflict Type	Definition	Example
Intra-group conflict	C2C conflicts whereby consumers who appear to support the same brand engage in uncivil discourse	“ User 1 : I was in a que with a friend who pointed out a dead one on a cake and then you could see tiny ones ying all over the place I think new cabinets that’s close would be better couldn’t believe they were still selling it all [sic] User 2 : @User 1 time a bit late for complaining now like ha. User 1 : @User 2 wasn’t complaining merely stating a fact So mind your own fucking business”
Inter-group conflict	C2C conflicts whereby consumers engage in uncivil discourse to defend the brand against brand adversaries	“ User 1 : Why is burger king so much more expensive than mcdonalds? 9 quid for a meal wtf you can go to ve guys for that. User 2 : Real food. User 3 : Obvious reasons, look at the quality of McDonald’s. User 4 : The food shits on Mcdonalds! User 5 : Because McDonald’s are crap!”
outer-group conflict	C2C conflicts whereby apparent non-supporters of the brand engage in uncivil discourse	“ User 1 : Is there a national carnivore week? Allllll the bacon. User 2 : Allllll the cancer and heart disease. Yum. User 1 : Did you know 100% of vegetarians die. No matter what they eat. User 2 : Yeah, but we don’t die as quickly as you would. Vegans live even longer!

Table 1. C2C Conflict Types. (Adopted from (Dineva & Daunt, 2023))

2.2 Typology of C2C conflict response strategies.

According to the Conflict Management Theory, conflict response strategies are categorized into Integrating, Obliging, Dominating, Avoiding, and Compromising by assertiveness and cooperativeness dimensions (Rahim, 2002; Rahim, 1983; Thomas & Kilmann, 1976). Various research has applied the Conflict Management Theory to propose conflict response strategies framework in the Online Brand Community context. At first, focusing on the For-Profit sector, Dineva et al. (2017) utilized the theory, and proposed five conflict management strategies used by brands on social media fan pages: non-engaging, censoring, bolstering, informing, and pacifying. Afterwards, Dineva et al. (2019) adopted the theory to distinguish positive (cooperative, trust-building) and negative (assertive, punitive) strategies. Another strategy framework that targets online firestorms is proposed by Herhausen et al. (2019), who frames firm response strategies into empathy, explanation, engaging, and disengaging. Next, (Dineva et al., 2020) further applied the theory in the Non-profit context, and proposed a C2C conflict management model containing six strategies. Finally, Dineva et al. (2023) integrated these findings into the Conflict Management Theory by classifying conflict management

strategies by tone (authoritative, cooperative) and approach (active, passive). This research will follow the Conflict Management Theory and empirical research built on this theory to distinguish firm response strategies. In Figure 2, the author demonstrates the Conflict Management Theory. The X axis represents Cooperativeness dimension; The Y axis represents Assertiveness dimension. According to how strong the assertiveness and cooperativeness, firm response strategies are categorized into five types.

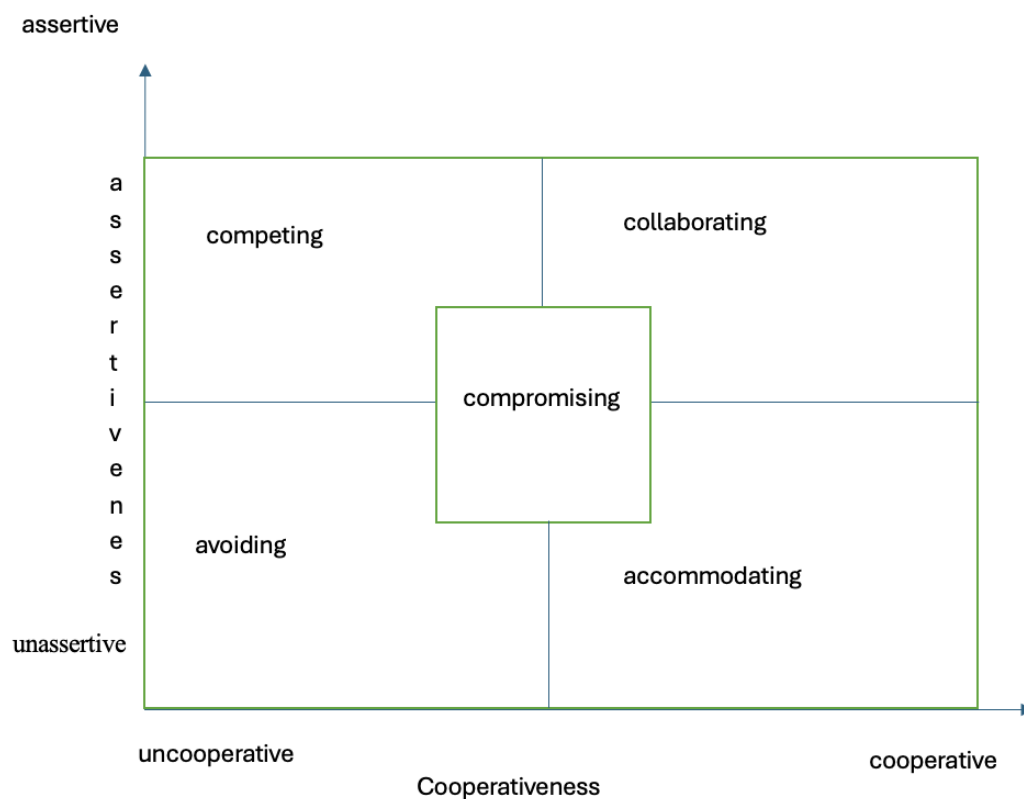


Figure 2. Conflict Management Theory

2.3 Effects of C2C Conflict response strategies

Social Identity Theory (SIT) posits that individuals derive part of their self-concept from membership in social groups, and strive to maintain a positive and distinct group identity through social categorization, identification and comparison (Tajfel & Turner, 2004; White & Argo, 2009). Empirical research either adopted SIT as the mechanism to explain the effects of C2C conflicts response strategies or utilized SIT as an indicator to demonstrate the effects of C2C conflicts response strategies. At the beginning, Ewing et al. (2013) found that C2C conflicts intensifies when community identity drives oppositional loyalty and in-group favoritism. Castle et al. (2014) showed that online community members' social identities drive negative or positive reactions towards brands' strategic changes. Afterward, Husemann et al. (2015) found that conflict management practices help support identity development. Next, Batista et al. (2022) proposed that assertive brand replies foster favorable attitudes by reinforcing in-group solidarity within activist brand communities. Similarly, Ilhan et al. (2022) found that responses to C2C conflicts amplify engagement as in-group fans are mobilized collectively to defend shared identity. Then, Ounvorawong et al. (2022) positions that bystander defense mitigates the damage of C2C conflicts through shared group identity. Meanwhile, Nepomuceno et al. (2023) found that response strategies emphasizing belongings strengthens community identity and engagement despite higher toxicity. Finally, Liao et al. (2025) concluded that consumer-targeted C2C conflicts increase brand advocacy by heightening perceived identity threat among brand supporters. This research will adopt SIT as the mechanism to explain the causal relationship between brand response and customer sentiment in inter-group conflict and intra-group conflict scenario. Because these two types of C2C conflicts happens between brand advocates and brand attackers. It is considered that brand advocates share the same group identity, while the brand attackers share another group identity.

Other research followed the Organizational Justice Theory (Folger & Bies, 1989). The Organizational Justice Theory explains how people's perceptions of fairness in organizational

processes, outcomes, and interpersonal treatment influence their attitudes and behaviors toward the organization. Gebauer et al. (2013) found that unfair responses result in negative customer behaviors. Adjei et al. (2016) introduces that firm's responses and perceived fairness help mitigate and patronage reduction caused by C2C conflicts. Bacile et al. (2018) followed the same theory and found that inappropriate firm responses threaten brand reputation and customer satisfaction through reduced perceived fairness. Finally, Wolter et al. (2023) found that C2C conflicts will drive long-term disengagement while brand responses fuel customers' defensive interactions through perceived injustice. This research will adopt the Organizational Justice Theory as the mechanism to explain the causal relationship between brand response and customer sentiment in outer-group conflict scenario. Since outer-group conflict involves unrelated persons with the brand, it is better to use the Organizational Justice theory to explain how brand response causes the sentiment of brand related persons.

Various research has studied the effects of firm responses on C2C conflicts using other theories. Within the research domain of customer purchase intention, empirical studies found that firm responses to C2C conflicts increase purchase intentions (Kumar et al., 2018; Zhang et al., 2014). Furthermore, in hedonic context, defensive firm responses drives more purchases, whereas in utilitarian settings, accommodative firm responses drives more purchases (Johnen & Schnittka, 2019). Targeting the research area of customer engagement, existing studies have identified that firm responses to C2C conflicts increase future customer review volume and future customer ratings (Sheng, 2019; Wang & Chaudhry, 2018).

Drawing on the empirical research, customer engagement, attitudes towards brands, and purchase intentions is most used as the indicator to measure the effects of C2C conflicts response strategies, and empirical research agrees that brands responses bring certain positive outcomes. Meanwhile, SIT and Organizational Justice Theory is most used as the mechanism to explain the effects of C2C conflicts response strategies. However, limited research studied how brand responses affect customers' sentiment in the C2C conflicts context. Sentiment

plays a critical role in driving customer engagement, purchase intention, and customer satisfaction (Chen et al., 2020; Geetha et al., 2017; Gooljar et al., 2024; Zhang et al., 2024). In addition, focusing on the online firestorm research context, Matook et al. (2022) stated that social media firestorms lead to both positive and negative sentiments. Herhausen et al. (2019) proposed that both sender-related factors and firm response strategies determine whether and how an online firestorm escalates which is partly measured by sentiment. In general, a research gap exists in studying how brands responses affect customers' sentiment in C2C conflict context.

2.4 Previous Research Methods

Among the literatures researching the effects of brand response strategies, two research methods are mostly used. The first method is gathering conflict data through netnography, then design a simulating C2C conflict environment, finally utilize a questionnaire survey to collect research participants' opinions towards brands responses (Dineva et al., 2025; Ilhan et al., 2022; Liao et al., 2025; Ounvorawong et al., 2022). Netnography is a qualitative research method developed by (Kozinets, 2002, 2010) that involves collecting online brand communities' comments data using public API. Since the experiment is simulated, the research participants did not fully involve into the C2C conflicts. As a result, biases may exist in the research. This research methods can interpret the causal relationships, but the results lack observational validation.

The second method is field studies. The researchers cooperate with a company, observing the real C2C conflicts, then using different response strategies to reply these C2C conflicts in real situations, finally collect real customer reactions (Husemann et al., 2015; Wu et al., 2021).

This approach brings the most authentic and unbiased data. However, some response strategies may bring negative consequences to customers and companies who were involved. For example, some response strategies may damage the brand image or harm customers'

sentiment. Plus, this approach examines only a single company within a single industry, which limits its generalizability and replicability. Furthermore, this approach is costly both in terms of money and time.

Overall, a research gap exists in improving the research methods for research in C2C conflicts context. In the online firestorm research area, various research has combined the netnography with sentiment analysis to have better validity. For example, Matook et al. (2022) used the netnography to collect historical firestorms data, then use the sentiment analysis tools to analyze the real customer sentiment. Hung et al. (2024) combined the netnography with LIWC, and found that hotels' expressions of thankfulness, sincerity, and interaction amplify positive emotion contagion, while apology, explanation, empathy, and remedy mitigate negative emotion contagion. Use netnography alongside with sentiment analysis combine the advantage of experiment method and field study. The combination uses real historical data, ensuring unbiased and authenticity of data. Furthermore, it is easy to conduct and reproduce, and it will not cause negative consequences because historical data is used. Finally, this approach can validate empirical research using experiment methods. In conclusion, a research gap exists in improving the data collection methods for research in C2C conflicts context. This research will follow combination of netnography and sentiment analysis approach.

3. Hypotheses Development

Theoretical Foundation: Social Identity Theory (SIT). The core premise of Social Identity Theory (SIT) posits that individuals define their self-concept through their membership in social groups (Tajfel & Turner, 2004). In Online Brand Communities (OBCs), users form strong "in-group" identities based on shared brand devotion. SIT suggests that individuals naturally strive for "positive distinctiveness" for their in-group and are highly sensitive to identity threats, whether they originate from within the group (intragroup) or from outsiders (inter/outergroup). Consequently, consumers evaluate brand responses not merely as customer

service interactions, but as actions by the "group representative" that either validate or threaten their social identity. The summary of hypotheses is shown in Table 2.

Hypothesis	Independent Var (response style)	Moderator (conflict type)	Expected Direction	Theoretical Mechanism
H1 (a-c)	All Conflict Types	(Baseline)	—	SIT: Conflict acts as an "Identity Threat," disrupting community harmony and social standing.
H2a	Assertiveness	Intragroup	—	SIT: Aggression toward "one of our own" violates in-group favoritism and interactional justice.
H2b	Assertiveness	Intergroup	+	SIT: Protecting the in-group by derogating the rival out-group.
H2c	Assertiveness	Outergroup	+	SIT: Assertiveness signals a strong defense of the community's values against "outsiders"
H3a	Cooperativeness	Intragroup	+	SIT: Restoring harmony through empathy; perceived as high interactional justice.
H3b	Cooperativeness	Intergroup	—	SIT: Being "nice" to a rival is perceived as a betrayal of the in-group's identity and loyalty.
H3c	Cooperativeness	Outergroup	—	SIT: Cooperative gestures toward illegitimate out-groups are perceived as a lack of brand loyalty to its fans

Table 2. Summary of Hypotheses

3.1 The Main Effect of C2C Conflicts on Customer Sentiment

C2C conflicts inherently disrupt the social harmony and identity stability of an OBC. From an SIT perspective, different types of conflicts threaten the group identity in varying ways, but all result in collective distress. In intragroup conflicts, the internal fighting shatters the illusion of in-group cohesion, causing disillusionment among members. In intergroup conflicts (e.g., clashes between rival brand factions) and outergroup conflicts (e.g., attacks from general non-members), the community's positive distinctiveness and boundaries are actively threatened by out-groups. This activates out-group derogation and defensive stress. Therefore, regardless of the conflict boundary, the presence of conflict introduces identity threats that negatively impact the emotional state of the community.

- **H1a: Intragroup conflict leads to negative sentiment.**
- **H1b: Intergroup conflict leads to negative sentiment.**
- **H1c: Outergroup conflict leads to negative sentiment.**

3.2 The Role of Assertiveness

Assertiveness involves communication that is dominant, firm, and authoritative. Under the SIT framework, how users perceive assertiveness depends on the identity of the opposing party. In an intragroup conflict, members expect the brand to act as a unifying figure. If the brand uses an assertive, heavy-handed approach against its own members, it violates the norm of in-group solidarity. It feels like a betrayal or an alienation by the group leader, which exacerbates identity threat and deepens negative emotions. Conversely, in intergroup and outergroup conflicts, the community faces an external threat. SIT posits that during intergroup competition; members expect their representative (the brand) to champion and fiercely defend the in-group's boundaries. An assertive brand response directed at out-group challengers validates the in-group's superiority, provides a sense of protection, and satisfies the members' need for positive distinctiveness, thereby generating positive sentiment.

- **H2a: The interaction between assertiveness and intragroup conflict leads to negative sentiment.**
- **H2b: The interaction between assertiveness and intergroup conflict leads to positive sentiment.**
- **H2c: The interaction between assertiveness and outergroup conflict leads to positive sentiment.**

3.3 The Role of Cooperativeness

Cooperativeness involves accommodating, polite, and consensus-seeking communication. SIT elegantly explains its divergent effects across conflict types. In intragroup conflicts, a

cooperative brand response is highly effective. By showing empathy and seeking reconciliation among internal members, the brand reinforces in-group cohesion, heals internal rifts, and validates the shared identity, ultimately fostering positive sentiment. However, in intergroup and outergroup conflicts, the dynamic flips. When the community is engaged in a defensive battle against outsiders, members expect loyalty and strong differentiation. If the brand adopts a cooperative or accommodating stance toward the out-group, in-group members perceive this as a sign of weakness or a compromise of their identity boundaries. By failing to exhibit "in-group favoritism," the cooperative brand response alienates its core members, leaving them feeling unsupported and leading to negative sentiment.

- **H3a: The interaction between cooperativeness and intragroup conflict leads to positive sentiment.**
- **H3b: The interaction between cooperativeness and intergroup conflict leads to negative sentiment.**
- **H3c: The interaction between cooperativeness and outergroup conflict leads to negative sentiment.**

4. Research Methods

4.1 Data Collection

This research will collect customer comments data from Reddit using the application API provided by Reddit official. Reddit is a large forum-style platform composed of thousands of topic-specific subreddits, where users share posts and engage in threaded, tree-structured discussions (Noor, 2023). The customer data will be collected from multiple companies from multiple industries. Data will be collected from the target companies' subreddit. only comments data will be collected. Next, all the users' IDs will be hash encrypted, except for the subreddit moderators, who represent the target companies. The author writes a python script to fetch the data. Based on the two-way exchange interactive characteristic of C2C conflict

several limitations are set in the script to collect the required data. First, only comments that have replies will be fetched, so that at least two customers are involved. Second, only comments that have replies from the subreddit moderators are fetched. This limitation is to make sure that brands have interfered the C2C conflicts. Third, After the reply of the subreddit moderators, other customers have commented. These comments that were posted after the moderators' replies will be used to conduct Sentiment Analysis to examine customers' sentiment after experiencing C2C conflicts and brands responses. The comments posted after the moderators' replies represent users who were simultaneously exposed to the C2C conflict and the brand's intervention, and these comments correspond to the same conflict event and the same brand response.

The author has chosen 68 brands owned subreddits to fetch data. These 68 brands come from 11 different industries. The Table 3 demonstrate the subreddits and industries from which data was collected. A total of 1148 conversations were collected.

Industry Sector	Entities
Technology Hardware / Consumer Electronics	Apple, Samsung, Intel, AMD, Microsoft, Sony, Nintendo, IBM, Anker, Tile, Roomba (iRobot), Ring, Peloton, Tesla, SpaceX, Boeing
Aerospace / Automotive / Transportation	Toyota, Kia, Porsche, Lamborghini, Lufthansa
Internet / Software / Platform	Google (Alphabet), Snapchat (Snap Inc.), Valve (Steam), Riot Games, Ubisoft, Hulu, Uber, DoorDash, Salesforce, Adobe, Heroku, Vercel, Udemy, Hinge (Hinge App), Etsy, LinkedIn
Telecommunications	T-Mobile
Retail	Walmart, Target, Costco, Amazon, Shopify
Logistics	FedEx, UPS, DHL, USPS
Food & Beverage	Starbucks, Taco Bell, Chipotle, Domino's Pizza, Wendy's
Finance	Chase (JPMorgan Chase), Stripe, PayPal, Coinbase
Hospitality	Hilton
Non-Profit Organizations	Sea Shepherd, PETA, Planned Parenthood, Black Lives Matter, Antifascists of Reddit, Ethereum, NASA
Religious Organizations	Scientology

Table 3. Data Source

4.2 Data Processing

After collecting the data, the author annotates each conversation manually. The aim of the annotation is to identify the conflict type and to exclude non-conflict conversations. The annotation process follows the framework proposed by (Dineva et al., 2023) who categorize C2C conflicts into intragroup conflict, intergroup conflict, and outergroup conflict. The user comments before the brand response are read to determine the conflict type. After the annotation, each conversation corresponds to a conflict type, which allows this research to compare the effectiveness of brand responses under different conflict types. After manual annotation, 495 C2C conflict conversations were identified, among which are 188 intragroup conflicts, 164 intergroup conflicts, and 143 outergroup conflicts. Hence, the number of observations of this research is 495. In the Data Analysis part, the conflict type will be one of the independent variables. conflict type is a categorical variable that will be converted into dummy variables.

The dependent variable of this research is customers' sentiment after experiencing both C2C conflict and brand response. Google NLP is used to quantify user comments' sentiments. Google NLP quantifies the emotion of a text, then output an emotion score between -1 and 1. Closer to 1, more positive the emotion, Closer to -1, more negative the emotion. User comments published after brand responses are used to calculate emotion scores. because these users have experienced both C2C conflict and a brand response. Since there are multiple user comments follow a brand response, the average emotion score of these user comments is calculated. This average emotion score represents the overall customer emotion after experiencing a C2C conflict and a brand response. This average emotion score is the dependent variable of this research.

The Independent Variables of this research are C2C conflict type, Assertiveness of brand response, and the Cooperativeness of brand response. The C2C conflict type is a categorical variable that is obtained by manual annotation. Following the Conflict Management Theory, brand responses are categorized by assertiveness and cooperativeness. Hence, this research uses assertiveness and cooperativeness as independent variables to represents brand responses. assertiveness and cooperativeness of brand responses are quantified using LIWC. LIWC is a dictionary-based linguistic analysis tool that identifies and quantifies emotional and psychological cues in textual content (Tausczik & Pennebaker, 2010). This research did not use Google NLP to quantify assertiveness and assertiveness because the Google NLP can only output the emotion score. There are not a LIWC dimension that directly quantify assertiveness or cooperativeness. Following the method of Waters et al. (2016) , this research uses aggregated index to represent assertiveness and cooperativeness. Assertiveness is indexed as: Certitude + Insight + Power + Cause - Tentativeness - Filler - Discrip - Nonfluent; Cooperativeness is indexed as: Social Behavior + Prosocial + Polite + Social + Emotion Positive - Conflict - Swear - Emotion Negative.

To conclude, this research examines customers' sentiment after experiencing both C2C conflicts and brand responses. The dependent variable is the customers sentiment. Independent variables are conflict type, assertiveness indices, and cooperativeness indices.

4.3 Mathematical Model

To include categorical variables into regression, prior research suggests converting categorical variables into dummy variables (Wooldridge, 2020). However, the traditional Least Squares Dummy Variable (LSDV) method has interpretational limitations because the estimated coefficients depend on the choice of the reference category. To address this issue, this research adopts the partition LSDV method proposed by (Kennedy, 2003; Yip & Tsang, 2007). This approach partitions both the intercepts and slopes for each category. The partition

LSDV cuts the model into three segments, fits each segment separately, and then expresses the results in one combined formulation. As a results, each type can be set as a dummy variable without causing dummy trap (perfect multicollinearity). What's more, the dummy LSDV allows easier and more insightful interpretation. The implementation of partition LSDV is presented as follows.

Step 1: Define variables. The dependent variable is *customer sentiment* (Y). The categorical independent variable is *conflict type*, represented by three dummy variables D_k ($k = 1,2,3$), where D_1 denotes *intra-group conflict*, D_2 denotes *inter-group conflict*, and D_3 denotes *outer-group conflict*. For each dummy variable, we have:

$$D_1 = \begin{cases} 1, & \text{if intragroup conflict} \\ 0, & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

$$D_2 = \begin{cases} 1, & \text{if intergroup conflict} \\ 0, & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

$$D_3 = \begin{cases} 1, & \text{if outergroup conflict} \\ 0, & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

Two continuous predictors are included: *Assertiveness* (Z_1), and *Cooperativeness* (Z_2).

Step 2: Construct partition terms. For each conflict type k and each continuous variable Z_j , a partition term $D_k \times Z_j$ is created ($k = 1,2,3; j = 1,2$). Thus, each group contains three components: its intercept and two group-specific slopes for brand-response attributes. And there will be three groups.

Step 3: Specify the model.

$$Y = \sum_{k=1}^3 (\gamma_k D_k + \beta_{k1} D_k Z_1 + \beta_{k2} D_k Z_2) + \varepsilon$$

Equation 1. LSDV Mathematical Model

where γ_k represents the intercept and β_{kj} is the slope of predictor Z_j for group k . This formulation allows each conflict-type group to have its own regression equation. that is, each group has its own intercept and slopes, thereby enabling direct statistical comparisons of slope differences across groups.

Step 4: Interpreting data.

Following the partition LSDV approach, for within group interpretation, the author will analyze the value of β_{k1} and β_{k2} . For instance, if β_{k1} is significantly positive, it indicates that a more assertive in brand responses increases customer sentiment within conflict type k ; if β_{k2} is significantly positive, it means that a stronger cooperativeness increases customer sentiment in group k .

Overall, the partition LSDV model allows this research to find how brand responses affect the customer sentiments in different conflict types.

5. Results and Hypotheses Testing

To examine the proposed hypotheses, the author employed a partition Least Square Dummy Variables (LSDV) regression model. This approach allows for the simultaneous estimation of baseline sentiment levels (intercepts) across various conflict scenarios and the specific moderating effects of brand response strategies (slopes). To ensure robust statistical inference,

standard errors were clustered at the subreddit level, accounting for unobserved correlations within specific community environments. The regression results are summarized in Table 4.

Observations	495
R-squared	0.051
Adjusted R-squared	0.035
Covariance type	Cluster-robust

Variable	Hypotheses	Path (Independent Variable → Sentiment)	Coeff. (β)	Std. Error	Z-Statistics	Decision
D_intragroup	H1a	Intragroup Conflict → Customer Sentiment	-0.0918***	0.028	-3.311	Supported
D_intergroup	H1b	Intergroup Conflict → Customer Sentiment	-0.1993***	0.024	-8.466	Supported
D_outergroup	H1c	Outergroup Conflict → Customer Sentiment	-0.1694***	0.026	-6.485	Supported
A_intragroup	H2a	Assertiveness x Intragroup Conflict → Customer Sentiment	-0.0084	0.017	-0.488	Not Supported
A_intergroup	H2b	Assertiveness x Intergroup Conflict → Customer Sentiment	-0.0495*	0.021	-2.391	Not Supported
A_outergroup	H2c	Assertiveness x Outergroup Conflict → Customer Sentiment	0.0044	0.013	0.343	Not Supported
C_intragroup	H3a	Cooperativeness x Intragroup Conflict → Customer Sentiment	-0.0360*	0.018	-1.964	Not Supported
C_intergroup	H3b	Cooperativeness x Intergroup Conflict → Customer Sentiment	-0.0557**	0.019	-2.857	Supported
C_outergroup	H3c	Cooperativeness x Outergroup Conflict → Customer Sentiment	-0.0257	0.024	-1.052	Not Supported

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.

Table 4. Regression results summary table

Hypotheses H1a, H1b, and H1c suggest that C2C conflicts threaten social identity and negatively impact consumer sentiment. These baseline effects are captured by the coefficients of the dummy variables D_intragroup, D_intergroup, D_outergroup. As shown in Table 4, in the absence of brand intervention, all three conflict types significantly depress consumer sentiment. Specifically, the intercepts for intragroup conflict ($\beta = -0.0918$, $p < 0.001$), intergroup conflict ($\beta = -0.1993$, $p < 0.001$), and outergroup conflict ($\beta = -0.1694$, $p < 0.001$) are all significantly negative. Consistent with Social Identity Theory (SIT), these results indicate that conflict visibility and identity threats lead to a decline in emotional valence across the board. Notably, intergroup conflicts, which involve clashes between rival

fan bases, exhibit the most severe negative impact on sentiment. Consequently, H1a, H1b, and H1c are strongly supported by the data.

Regarding the moderating role of assertive brand responses, H2 posits that the impact of assertiveness is contingent on the conflict boundary. In the case of intragroup conflicts (H2a), while the coefficient was directional ($\beta = -0.0084$), it did not reach statistical significance, leading to a lack of support for H2a. In intergroup conflicts (H2b), we hypothesized that assertiveness would bolster in-group identity and yield positive sentiment; however, the results reveal a significant negative effect ($\beta = -0.0495$, $p < 0.05$). This indicates that assertive communication in intergroup disputes exacerbates negative sentiment, thereby refuting H2b. For outergroup conflicts (H2c), the interaction effect of assertiveness was found to be statistically insignificant, resulting in the rejection of H2c. These findings suggest that assertive brand interventions may fail to provide the identity protection predicted by SIT, instead potentially intensifying the hostility within the community.

The final set of hypotheses, H3, investigates the moderating influence of cooperative brand responses. In intragroup conflicts (H3a), SIT predicts that cooperativeness restores group harmony; however, the empirical results show a significant negative impact ($\beta = -0.0360$, $p < 0.05$). Since the result is in the opposite direction of the prediction, H3a is refuted.

Conversely, H3b predicted that cooperativeness toward an out-group rival would be perceived as a betrayal of the in-group, causing negative sentiment. The data confirms this prediction with a significant negative coefficient ($\beta = -0.0557$, $p < 0.01$), suggesting that "friendly" gestures toward rivals alienate the brand's own community members and providing strong support for H3b. Finally, for outergroup conflicts (H3c), the interaction effect was negative but not statistically significant ($\beta = -0.0257$), meaning H3c is not supported. Overall, the results highlight a complex dynamic where brand cooperativeness can backfire if it is perceived as compromising group boundaries.

6. Discussion

The empirical findings provide only partial support for the theoretical expectations developed from Social Identity Theory (SIT) and Organizational Justice Theory. In brief, hypotheses H1a, H1b, and H1c are supported, confirming that all three types of C2C conflict significantly depress customer sentiment, while H3b is also supported, suggesting that cooperativeness in intergroup conflict may be interpreted negatively by in-group members. However, the unsupported hypotheses are theoretically more revealing, as they demonstrate that the effectiveness of brand responses in online brand communities is constrained by important boundary conditions beyond simple in-group versus out-group matching.

First, H2a predicted that assertiveness in intragroup conflict would lead to more negative sentiment, yet the effect was not statistically significant. One possible explanation is that intragroup conflicts in online brand communities are often normatively ambiguous rather than clearly deviant. In such situations, an assertive brand response may be interpreted in two opposing ways. On the one hand, according to SIT, harsh intervention toward one's own members may threaten in-group belonging and therefore provoke dissatisfaction. On the other hand, from a procedural justice perspective, some community members may welcome a firm intervention if they perceive the conflict as requiring order restoration and boundary enforcement. These opposite evaluative mechanisms may offset each other, making the overall effect statistically insignificant. In other words, assertiveness within intragroup conflict does not consistently function as either "betrayal" or "leadership"; rather, its meaning depends on whether users view the brand as suppressing members unfairly or fulfilling its governance role appropriately.

Second, H2b predicted that assertiveness in intergroup conflict would improve sentiment by signaling in-group protection, but the empirical results reveal the opposite. This suggests that

SIT alone is insufficient to explain brand evaluations in highly visible digital environments. Although assertiveness toward rival groups may theoretically reinforce in-group distinctiveness, brand representatives are not evaluated purely as fellow group members; they are also judged as institutional actors. Once the brand adopts an aggressive or confrontational tone, users may assess the response through the lens of interactional justice, expecting politeness, self-restraint, and legitimacy rather than emotional escalation. As a result, assertiveness that was expected to signal protection may instead be interpreted as incivility, unprofessionalism, or reputational risk. Moreover, intergroup conflicts are already emotionally intense. In such contexts, an assertive brand response may amplify conflict salience and emotional contagion, thereby worsening the overall affective climate rather than calming it. Thus, when identity defense is enacted through an excessively combative style, the symbolic benefit of “standing with us” may be outweighed by the broader social cost of appearing hostile.

Third, H2c proposed that assertiveness in outergroup conflict would generate positive sentiment, but no significant effect was found. This finding indicates that when the attackers are not meaningful members of the brand community, assertive defense may simply lack diagnostic value for core users. Unlike intergroup conflict, outergroup conflict may not activate strong social comparison processes because the outside actors are often perceived as irrelevant, unserious, or lacking legitimate standing within the community. Under these conditions, a forceful brand response may neither meaningfully strengthen in-group identity nor substantially improve users’ emotions. From the perspective of justice theory, users may also regard strong responses to marginal outsiders as disproportionate, unnecessary, or strategically wasteful. Therefore, assertiveness does not translate into emotional benefits in outergroup settings because the conflict itself may not be important enough to justify a forceful defense.

Fourth, H3a predicted that cooperativeness in intragroup conflict would restore harmony and improve sentiment, yet the observed effect is significantly negative. This result suggests that conciliatory communication is not always perceived as constructive in internal disputes. In intragroup conflicts, community members are often not merely seeking emotional soothing; they are seeking norm clarification, responsibility attribution, and fair resolution. A cooperative response that emphasizes accommodation, politeness, or harmony may therefore be interpreted as avoiding judgment, flattening moral distinctions, or refusing to address the substantive issue at stake. From a procedural justice perspective, such a response may appear weak or evasive because it fails to demonstrate that the brand can decisively uphold group norms. From an SIT perspective, this can also threaten members' sense of identity security: if the brand does not clearly defend acceptable standards of in-group conduct, members may feel that the community boundary has become vague and insufficiently protected. Accordingly, cooperativeness may backfire in intragroup conflict because it is read not as reconciliation, but as indecisiveness or "toxic positivity."

Fifth, H3c predicted that cooperativeness in outergroup conflict would reduce sentiment, but the effect was not statistically significant. A plausible interpretation is that cooperativeness toward outsiders in these situations is often treated by users as low-stakes communication. Because outergroup actors are not central to the community's identity structure, members may not scrutinize the brand's accommodating tone as closely as in intergroup settings. In other words, cooperativeness toward a true rival group may look like disloyalty, but cooperativeness toward loosely connected outsiders may simply appear as routine civility. At the same time, such civility may not be sufficiently meaningful to improve sentiment either, because it does not directly resolve the emotional residue of the original conflict. This produces a null effect: cooperative responses neither seriously alienate the in-group nor substantially reassure it. The insignificance of H3c therefore implies that outergroup conflict may be governed less by symbolic identity concerns and more by issue salience; when the external actor is peripheral, response style becomes less consequential.

Taken together, these unsupported hypotheses point to an important theoretical implication: brand response effectiveness in C2C conflict cannot be understood through a simple congruence logic in which assertiveness is always appropriate against outsiders and cooperativeness is always appropriate toward insiders. Instead, response styles are filtered through users' simultaneous evaluations of group identity, procedural fairness, and interactional appropriateness. This means that the same response style may carry different social meanings depending on whether users interpret the brand primarily as an in-group representative, a conflict mediator, or a public institutional actor. Therefore, the present findings extend prior C2C conflict research by showing that the emotional consequences of brand intervention depend not only on conflict type, but also on whether the response satisfies users' expectations of justice, legitimacy, and community governance.

7. Theoretical Implications

The findings of this study generate several theoretical implications for the literature on consumer-to-consumer (C2C) conflict management in online brand communities. First, the consistent support for H1a, H1b, and H1c strengthens the core proposition of Social Identity Theory (SIT): visible conflicts in online brand communities operate as identity threats that depress collective emotional valence. This result is highly consistent with prior literature suggesting that online brand conflicts are not merely interpersonal disagreements, but socially meaningful confrontations shaped by group categorization, oppositional loyalty, and in-group favoritism (Ewing et al., 2013; Castle et al., 2014; Dineva & Daunt, 2023). In particular, the finding that intergroup conflict produces the most negative baseline sentiment extends earlier studies that emphasized the salience of intergroup boundaries in digital brand spaces. It is also in line with Liao et al. (2025), who argued that brand-related attacks heighten perceived identity threat among supporters, and with Ilhan et al. (2022), who showed that attacks and defenses among brand fans activate strong collective reactions. However, whereas these prior

studies mainly highlighted engagement, defense, or advocacy outcomes, the present study demonstrates that the emotional baseline of the community remains negative even before considering the style of brand intervention. Thus, this research refines the literature by showing that identity activation in conflict situations may increase participation or advocacy in some contexts, yet still simultaneously depress overall sentiment.

Second, the results complicate the dominant SIT-based assumption that brand responses should be evaluated mainly through the logic of in-group protection. In the literature review, studies such as Batista et al. (2022), Ilhan et al. (2022), Ounvorawong et al. (2022), Nepomuceno et al. (2023), and Liao et al. (2025) collectively suggest that stronger defense of the in-group can mobilize supporters, reinforce belonging, or generate more favorable outcomes. The present findings only partially align with that stream. On the one hand, the significant negative effect of cooperativeness in intergroup conflict (H3b supported) is broadly consistent with SIT and with previous arguments that communities react negatively when brands appear insufficiently loyal to the in-group. In this sense, the study supports the logic behind prior work showing that identity-threatening episodes intensify demands for group protection and that conciliatory gestures toward rivals may be interpreted as weakness or betrayal (Ilhan et al., 2022; Liao et al., 2025). On the other hand, the refutation of H2b directly challenges the expectation that assertive defense in intergroup conflict necessarily produces favorable reactions. Batista et al. (2022), for example, suggested that assertive replies can reinforce solidarity and improve attitudes in activist contexts, while Ilhan et al. (2022) emphasized the mobilizing effect of attack-defense dynamics. By contrast, this study finds that assertiveness in intergroup conflict significantly worsens sentiment. Therefore, rather than fully rejecting these earlier studies, the present findings qualify them by showing that the positive value of assertive defense is not universal; it depends on the evaluative criterion being used. A response style that increases defense, advocacy, or mobilization may still reduce emotional valence if community members perceive it as excessively hostile, embarrassing, or socially inappropriate.

Third, this study advances the C2C conflict literature by demonstrating that Organizational Justice Theory is not merely relevant in outergroup settings, but also functions as an important boundary condition on SIT in intergroup and intragroup settings. Research grounded in Organizational Justice Theory argued that firm responses are judged in terms of fairness, appropriateness, and interpersonal treatment, and that unfair or inappropriate responses trigger negative reactions (Gebauer et al., 2013; Adjei et al., 2016; Bacile et al., 2018; Wolter et al., 2023). The present results strongly support this stream of literature. The negative coefficient for assertiveness in intergroup conflicts suggests that even when a brand is symbolically defending its own community, users do not evaluate the response solely through group loyalty; they also assess whether the brand communicates with dignity, restraint, and civility. This supports Bacile et al. (2018) and Wolter et al. (2023), both of whom emphasized that inappropriate or uncivil firm behavior can damage satisfaction, engagement, and perceptions of justice. It also resonates with Adjei et al. (2016), who argued that firm responsiveness mitigates the damage of C2C conflict when it is perceived as fair. Accordingly, the present study extends justice-based research by showing that interactional justice can override the expected benefits of out-group derogation. In other words, a brand may successfully signal “we are on your side,” yet still harm sentiment if the way it communicates violates shared norms of respectful conduct.

Fourth, the refutation of H3a makes an additional theoretical contribution by challenging the common assumption that cooperative responses are inherently restorative in internal community disputes. In the hypotheses development, cooperativeness in intragroup conflict was expected to heal internal rifts by reaffirming cohesion. Yet the results show the opposite: cooperative responses in intragroup conflict significantly reduce sentiment. This finding complicates prior literature that tends to treat accommodation, empathy, or reconciliation as beneficial forms of moderation (Dineva et al., 2017; Dineva et al., 2019; Herhausen et al., 2019; Dineva et al., 2025). Rather than indicating that cooperative communication is always

ineffective, the result suggests that its effectiveness depends on whether the conflict is primarily interpreted as an emotional dispute or as a norm violation requiring authoritative adjudication. In intragroup conflicts, users may expect the brand not merely to soothe emotions but to restore procedural order and clearly enforce community norms. Under such conditions, a highly cooperative response may be perceived as indecisive, hypocritical, or as a form of conflict avoidance. This interpretation is theoretically consistent with Folger and Bies (1989) and the broader procedural justice tradition, because it implies that members are evaluating whether the brand is acting as a legitimate and competent authority. Therefore, the study contributes a more nuanced account of cooperativeness: it is not a universally positive strategy, but one whose effect depends on whether members prioritize harmony restoration or norm enforcement.

Fifth, this study also contributes to the broader response-strategy literature by helping explain why prior studies often report more positive effects of firm responses than the present research does. Much of the existing work has used outcomes such as purchase intention, engagement, future ratings, or advocacy (Kumar et al., 2018; Wang & Chaudhry, 2018; Sheng, 2019). By contrast, this study focuses specifically on post-intervention sentiment. This distinction matters theoretically. A response can stimulate engagement, intensify defense behavior, or even increase advocacy, while still worsening the emotional atmosphere of the community. This may explain why the present findings appear more pessimistic than some earlier studies. In this sense, the study does not simply contradict the prior literature; it reveals that different dependent variables capture different layers of consumer reaction. Engagement-based studies may overestimate the success of aggressive or identity-affirming responses if they do not also consider emotional deterioration. Thus, the present research extends the literature by positioning sentiment as a distinct and indispensable evaluative dimension in C2C conflict management. This point is especially important given prior work showing that sentiment has downstream implications for engagement, satisfaction, and behavioral outcomes (Chen et al., 2020; Geetha et al., 2017; Gooljar et al., 2024; Zhang et al., 2024).

Overall, the theoretical contribution of this study lies in moving the literature beyond a simple “identity match” logic. Existing SIT-based research correctly suggests that conflict boundaries matter and that communities expect brands to defend shared identities. However, the current findings show that identity congruence alone is insufficient to explain favorable outcomes. A brand response must not only align with group boundaries, but also satisfy users’ expectations of interactional and procedural justice. Consequently, this study integrates Social Identity Theory with Organizational Justice Theory in a more symmetrical way: SIT explains why different conflict boundaries trigger different expectations, while Organizational Justice Theory explains why some identity-consistent responses still backfire. In doing so, the study supports the broader C2C conflict literature on the importance of group dynamics and fairness perceptions, while also revising prior assumptions that assertiveness and cooperativeness are predictably beneficial when matched to the “appropriate” conflict type.

8. Managerial Implications

From a practical standpoint, the empirical results provide managers with a scenario-based strategic framework for deploying assertiveness and cooperativeness during community crises. When navigating intragroup conflicts among loyal users, brands must eschew overly assertive suppression, which triggers feelings of betrayal, while also avoiding purely cooperative platitudes that appear weak. Instead, managers should adopt a balanced approach characterized by moderate cooperativeness and high procedural fairness, focusing on transparent mediation and addressing the root cause rather than offering superficial emotional appeasement. Conversely, intergroup conflicts demand a highly cautious strategy of tactful defense. As evidenced by the theoretical refutation of H2b and the support for H3b, managers must navigate a precarious middle ground: exhibiting cooperativeness toward rival fans alienates the core user base, yet aggressively attacking the out-group violates social decorum and damages the brand's public image. Recalling the PETA controversy discussed earlier, the

brand's overtly assertive validation of one ideological side over another acted as a catalyst for hostility rather than a resolution. Therefore, in intergroup scenarios, brands should maintain dignified neutrality, utilizing low cooperativeness and low-to-moderate assertiveness to reaffirm their core community values without directly engaging in the toxic crossfire. Finally, for outergroup conflicts involving non-stakeholders or external instigators, the statistical insignificance of both assertive and cooperative interventions suggests that a cold treatment or standard public relations response is optimal. By utilizing low assertiveness and low cooperativeness, brands deprive external instigators of the visibility required to further disrupt the community's emotional equilibrium. The strategic framework is demonstrated in Table 5.

Conflict Type	Participant Dynamics	Recommended Assertiveness	Recommended Cooperativeness	Core Strategic Orientation
Intragroup	Loyal Fans vs. Loyal Fans	Low	Low to Moderate	Avoiding or Compromising
Intergroup	In-group Fans vs. Rival Out-group	Low	Low	Avoiding
Outergroup	Out-group rivals vs. Out-group rivals	Moderate	Moderate	Compromising or Collaborating or Accomodating

Table 5. C2C conflict response strategy matrix

9. Limitations and Future Research

Despite its contributions, this study is subject to certain limitations that present avenues for future scholarly inquiry. Primarily, the empirical data was exclusively derived from Reddit, a platform characterized by specific normative behaviors, anonymity, and a generally higher tolerance for combative discourse. Future research should replicate this study across platforms with differing architectural and cultural norms, such as LinkedIn or Instagram, to ascertain the generalizability of these findings. Furthermore, the current methodology relies

on the textual analysis of consumer sentiment. As digital communication increasingly pivots toward multimedia formats, subsequent studies could investigate how the modality of a brand's response, such as an apologetic video on TikTok versus a formal written statement moderates the relationship between conflict boundaries and emotional contagion.

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